

SAN NICOLAS' LAST WOMAN

Feminine Robinson Crusoe Who
Lived Alone More Than
Seventeen Years.

Deserted Island in the Pacific Long
the Home of a Solitary
Indian.

History of the Removal of a Tribe and
the Neglect of its One
Member.

During the present summer the writer made the attempt to land on the island of San Nicolas, an almost barren mass of sand lying sixty miles off the coast of Southern California, the extreme outlying point of the coast, says a correspondent of the New York Post. We passed the little island of Santa Barbara late in the afternoon, and at 7 o'clock were five miles from the outer island. This island lies in an area of constant gales and is almost unapproachable except during the calm periods of the winter, and even then, owing to the storms that suddenly rise, it is a dangerous place for yachts. Notwithstanding this, San Nicolas has had within two centuries a vigorous native population, and with its barren shores is associated a true story that bears all the essentials of a romance of the Crusoe order. Within the present cen-

Cruce order. Within the present century the last of the natives were taken ashore by order of the priests at the Santa Barbara mission, under instructions from the Mexican government. The Indians had been living there from time immemorial, subsisting on fish (and shellfish), with which the waters abound. A vessel was sent to the island, and all the Indians were taken aboard with the exception of one woman whose child or children had been forgotten. It is believed that a gale was coming on, and that the skipper found his little craft in danger, and so put off. Others say that the woman was purposely deserted. In any event, the boat sailed away, leaving her standing alone on the beach, and being "only an Indian woman." It probably mattered little to the other hunters, who were glad to get away from the rough coast. When the Indians were landed at Santa Barbara, it was said to be the intention of the captain to return and rescue the woman, but not long after the sloop was wrecked, and so the months and years slipped away, and the story of the lost woman became almost a legend, her appearance often being pictured by the story tellers of the day and her one quaint cry of "Maneuauna!" being repeated to credulous listeners. Seventeen years went by, and the woman was almost forgotten, until finally Padre Gonzales, excited by curiosity to learn her fate, hired a resident of Santa Barbara to make a careful search for her, and as a result three unsuccessful trips were made to the island. On the last Captain Niderer took several Indians and after futile attempts succeeded in landing. They soon found evidence that some one lived on the island, discovering a basket containing feathers. This they disturbed, and upon visiting it the following day found the feathers replaced.

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It was evident that the woman was avoiding them, so they formed a line as well as they could across the island and marched in regular order 200 yards apart. Even then they could not find her, and it was only when they had nearly given up the hunt that one of the party finally stumbled upon three huts and the woman, who was sitting on the ground skinning a seal, with a wild dog beside her, who growled fiercely at the strangers. The man signalled to the others, and the entire party were soon gathered about the woman, who had lived a life as remarkable as that of Crusoe. She could not understand a word that was said. The Indians of the party, thinking that she was a sacred person, fell on their knees before her. She was a comely woman, 40 or 50 years of age, dressed in the skins of sea birds, or shags, which were fastened to seal skin. About her were baskets cleverly made, and to the windward of her hut, which was made of the ribs of a whale, she had built a windbreak of birch and grass. She had dishes of stone in which she ground roots of various kinds, and her clothes were sewed with thread made from seal skin and with needles from the bones of birds. She consented to go aboard the vessel, and was carried to Santa Barbara with all her belongings, which were considered great curiosities, her dress of skins being sent to Rome to the pope.

At Santa Barbara she lived in the family of one of her rescuers, and though Indians from all over the state visited her, no one could be found who could understand her. She was a perfect child, playing for hours at a time and making signs which could not be interpreted. She was baptized and given a Spanish name, and at her death was buried in the old mission graveyard, having survived the change from savage to civilized life less than two months.